condemned our arrest. I wondered what Vikram Sarabhai would have done in these circumstances.

MEETING VIKRAM SARABHAI

'They call me Vikram.'

I was attached to the rocket engineering division headed by Abdul Kalam, who had joined Sarabhai's group of 'space men' in 1963 from DRDO. It was a team of just five of us—Kalam, V Sudhakar, M K Abdul Majeed, C R Satya and me. Closely associated with us for payload integration were a bunch of scientists Sarabhai had selected from Physical Research Laboratory, Ahmedabad, including O P N Calla, Satyaprakash, E V Chitnis and P D Bhavsar.

The five-member rocket engineering division comprised four tables joined, around which we sat the most informal way imaginable in a government office. There was no designated desk for anyone, including Kalam, though we all had a drawer or two to keep stationery. I might look for a design paper and find it where Majeed was sitting; Kalam would lean over to borrow a pen from me. We had two draftsmen, Alex and Achari, who worked in another room of the church. Then we had Thankappan Nair, Kalam's personal assistant who ended up being an assistant for all the five of us. Thankappan Nair was called a walking dictionary, and often people called out to him with such questions: 'Thankappan Nair, how do you spell euphoria?' Director Murthy's office was in the nearby Bishop House.

India was into something big, as Indira Gandhi and Vikram Sarabhai saw it, but it was not clear even to them on how we were to go about it. Sarabhai, who was a terror at the Department of Atomic Energy, adopted a totally different approach here. He thought since there was no systemic plan —though he was clear that applications of space science would one day turn India into a super power—it was best to let things be fluid, let people